

BUND PHILIPPINISCHER
GESUNDHEITSKRÄFTE IN ÖSTERREICH

2ND NATIONAL CONGRESS

IN COLLABORATION WITH AK-SALZBURG



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“Strengthening Collaboration and Opportunities: Advancing Philippine Healthcare Force Integration, Healthcare Professional Law, Recruitment and Retention Strategies”

The 2nd National Congress, held on April 12, 2025, in Salzburg, brought together key stakeholders to support the growing Filipino healthcare workforce in Austria. Organized by BPGÖ, the event focused on strengthening collaboration between Austria and the Philippines through discussions on integration, professional law, recruitment, and retention strategies. It served as a platform to promote understanding, share knowledge, and align policies for the benefit of internationally educated healthcare professionals (IEHPs).



● **Ms. Daniela Wiermeier: AK VP, Salzburg**

Vice President of AK Salzburg, opened the 2nd National Congress with a warm welcome and a strong message of support for Filipino healthcare professionals. She emphasized the importance of collaboration, fair working conditions, and equal opportunities. Her remarks highlighted the need for continued partnership between Austria and the Philippines to support the integration and growth of internationally educated healthcare workers.

She acknowledged the growing contribution of Filipino healthcare professionals in Austria and reaffirmed the Chamber of Labor's commitment to protecting their rights, improving working conditions, and promoting equal opportunities for all workers, regardless of nationality.

Her presence and message set the tone for a day of collaboration, inspiration, and forward-thinking, and reminded everyone that supporting internationally educated professionals is not just a necessity—but a shared responsibility.

Strengthening Bilateral Ties

A powerful keynote by **Mr. Zoilo Velasco, Deputy Head of Mission, Consul General, and Deputy Permanent Representative to the United Nations of the Philippine Embassy and Mission in Vienna**. His message, "Fostering Bilateral Cooperation Between the Philippines and Austria," underscored the vital diplomatic role of both nations in shaping fair labor policies, safeguarding workers' rights, and strengthening the cultural and professional integration of Filipino nurses in Austria. Mr. Velasco emphasized the need for continued dialogue and mutual respect to nurture this growing healthcare partnership.



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Understanding Professional Law in Austria

● Topic: "Overview of Professional Law and Its Impact on Foreign Nationals in Austria"

Mr. Norbert Piberger, BSc, LL.M. Legal Expert, Chamber of Workers and Employees (AK), delivered an in-depth look into Austria's professional legal framework, with special attention to laws affecting non-EU workers in regulated professions such as nursing. He discussed the significance of diploma recognition, residency regulations, employment rights, and challenges often encountered by foreign professionals navigating Austrian bureaucracy. His session empowered participants to better understand their legal standing and seek the proper avenues for professional growth. He shed light on common bureaucratic challenges faced by internationally educated healthcare workers, including delays in recognition, language requirements, and lack of legal awareness.



Role of Local Government in Integration and Professional Growth

● Salzburg's Vision for Integration and Growth of Internationally Educated Healthcare Workers

Dr. Brigitta Pallauf, President of the State Parliament

(Landtagspräsidentin). Representative for Governor Dr. Wilfried Haslauer, emphasized the pivotal role that local government plays in ensuring the successful integration and professional development of internationally educated healthcare professionals. Representing the Governor of Salzburg, she outlined the region's multi-level support systems, which include programs focused on cultural inclusion, affordable housing, and educational access for the families of migrant workers.

She underscored that integration must go beyond policy—it must be people-centered, responsive to the daily realities of healthcare workers and their families. By connecting national strategies with local implementation, Salzburg aims to create a welcoming and supportive environment for foreign professionals, particularly in healthcare where demand continues to grow.

Dr. Pallauf also gave heartfelt recognition to the Filipino nurses and healthcare workers, commending their professionalism, compassion, and resilience. She called them a "pillar of Salzburg's healthcare services", highlighting how their contributions are deeply valued and essential to the sustainability of the system.



Recruitment and Retention – The Role of ABA

- **How the ABA Supports the Recruitment and Retention of Internationally Educated Healthcare Workers in Austria**



Mr. Raphael Ray Bacolod

Representative, Austrian Business Agency (ABA)

Presented the important work of the Austrian Business Agency (ABA) in addressing Austria's growing demand for healthcare professionals through international recruitment and long-term retention strategies. He explained how the ABA acts as a central coordination hub, helping healthcare institutions connect with qualified professionals abroad—particularly in high-need fields such as nursing.

Mr. Bacolod detailed the ABA's structured recruitment processes, including assistance with work and residence permits, fast-tracked visa applications, and pre-arrival support that eases the transition for foreign healthcare workers entering Austria. Through collaboration with Austrian employers and the government, the ABA helps ensure that the recruitment process is not only efficient but also ethically sound and sustainable.

He also stressed that successful recruitment must be accompanied by strong retention efforts. In this regard, the ABA supports foreign professionals by facilitating access to integration services, including language courses, cultural orientation, and mentorship programs that help newcomers settle and grow professionally. Additionally, the agency promotes ongoing training and educational opportunities to help healthcare workers expand their qualifications and advance their careers within the Austrian system.

Mr. Bacolod highlighted that the ABA is committed not just to filling staffing shortages, but to creating a supportive, long-term environment where international healthcare workers feel valued, integrated, and motivated to stay.



Successful Integration through the Austrian Integration Fund (ÖIF)

- **Navigating the Austrian Integration System: Programs, Language Courses, and Funding Opportunities**

Ms. Himmer's talk provided a practical roadmap for foreign workers. She introduced the ÖIF's structured language programs, integration modules, and funding resources available to migrants. Her session was particularly well-received by newly arrived nurses, many of whom are still navigating language and cultural adjustments. The session encouraged them to utilize the available services to ease their transition and confidently participate in Austrian society.



Ms. Milica Himmer, BSc MSc
Head of Integration Services for Skilled Workers, ÖIF

Department of Migrant Workers (DMW) – The Philippine Perspective

Atty. Delmer Cruz

- **Introduction of DMW and Approach to Labor Migration**

Representing the Department of Migrant Workers (DMW), Atty. Cruz introduced the department's mission to regulate, protect, and empower overseas Filipino workers.

He explained how DMW aims to make overseas employment a choice, not a necessity, and discussed mechanisms for resolving disputes, ensuring ethical recruitment, and providing reintegration support.



He encouraged Filipino workers to remain engaged with DMW's resources, both abroad and when returning home.



PANEL DISCUSSION: OPPORTUNITIES AND CHALLENGES FOR FOREIGN NATIONALS IN AUSTRIA



A dynamic panel moderated by Mr. Daniel Garces, Vice President of BPGÖ, allowed for an open exchange between:

- **Mr. Zoilo Velasco**
- **Mr. Norbert Piberger**
- **Ms. Milica Himmer**
- **Mr. Raphael Bacolod**
- **Mag. Karl Schweiger**
- **Atty. Delmer Cruz**

Topics included diploma recognition delays, emotional well-being of migrant workers, language barriers, and the need for more tailored integration support. The panel emphasized the collective responsibility of governments, institutions, and communities to build sustainable systems that value and retain internationally trained talent.

This session fostered a rich exchange of insights and lived experiences, examining the realities faced by internationally educated healthcare professionals (IEHPs) in Austria. Several core challenges were explored:

- Diploma and credential recognition delays that slow down employment and integration, creating uncertainty and frustration among qualified foreign professionals.
- The emotional and psychological toll of migration, often compounded by separation from family, work pressure, and cultural adjustments.
- Persistent language barriers, not only in clinical practice but also in daily life and accessing public services.
- The need for tailored integration support—beyond general programs—to meet the specific needs of healthcare workers and their families.



INFO BOOTH: NURSING DIPLOMA RECOGNITION



An information booth on the formal recognition of foreign academic nursing qualifications provided by representatives from various Universities of Applied Sciences (FHs) across Austria was available throughout the event. Many attendees received on-the-spot consultation about procedures, requirements, and timelines—a vital resource for career planning.



FUTURE OUTLOOK: CONTINUING THE MISSION



Mrs. Marjorie Akistoy, BScN

President, BPGÖ

● Looking Ahead: Future Initiatives and Strengthening Collaboration

Mrs. Akistoy concluded the event with an optimistic view of the future, emphasizing BPGÖ's ongoing commitment to advocacy, education, and support for Filipino nurses in Austria. She called for continuous collaboration, not just between Austria and the Philippines, but across sectors—government, legal, academic, and private—toward a truly inclusive and sustainable healthcare system. She also hinted at new programs, including mentorship networks and community outreach, planned for 2026.

A CELEBRATION OF UNITY AND PURPOSE

This year's congress was more than a formal event—it was a celebration of unity, courage, and purpose. With over 200 attendees, including newly arrived Filipino nurses, long-time residents, Austrian officials, and international guests, the congress served as a reminder of the power of collaboration and the shared responsibility to support one another in building resilient, diverse, and competent healthcare systems.

We thank everyone who participated, and we look forward to welcoming you again at the next National Congress in 2026.



ACKNOWLEDGMENTS AND GRATITUDE TO OUR SUPPORTERS

The success of the 2nd National Congress would not have been possible without the generous support and collaborative spirit of our sponsors, partners, and dedicated individuals.

We extend our deepest appreciation to our main sponsor, **SkillsHR International**, for their unwavering commitment to empowering the Filipino healthcare workforce and supporting this important event.

We are also grateful to our supporting sponsors who contributed to making this congress a meaningful and memorable experience: **Wie Daham, Vion, PDM, YJYA, Pinoy Relax, Infinity Balikpapan Cargo, Maribel Y. Homm Aesthetics**, and **IVF Express**.



Special thanks as well to the individuals who extended their personal support: **Cecile Orola Cech, Janet Heiss, Anna Yacat**, and **Angestellten Betriebsrat LKH**.

Your contributions—whether in resources, encouragement, or presence—played a vital role in the realization of this congress.

We would also like to thank **AK Salzburg** for their continued support of the Bund. Your generosity in providing the event hall accommodation created a professional and welcoming space for dialogue and learning.



A heartfelt shoutout to our talented emcees, **Ms. Beate Mae Bayta** and **Mr. Gerald Lopez**, whose energy, professionalism, and grace guided the program seamlessly from start to finish.



To all the **officers of the Bund**, thank you for your hard work behind the scenes. Your planning, coordination, and dedication are the backbone of this organization. This event was a success because of your teamwork and shared vision.

A special recognition goes to our Program Committee, whose tireless dedication and hard work ensured the smooth flow and success of the 2nd National Congress. Our heartfelt thanks to **Ms. Marjorie Albeza**, Head of the Program Committee, for her outstanding leadership, and to **Ms. Karel Jane Cabanting** for her invaluable support and contributions. Your careful planning, attention to detail, and unwavering commitment made a tremendous difference. Kudos to you both for a job exceptionally well done! Your efforts truly brought the event to life and created a meaningful experience for all participants.

Finally, to all our **participants**, your engagement and enthusiasm gave life to every session. We hope that the insights you gained from the congress will serve as a valuable resource in your personal and professional journey. Together, we made this event possible. Thank you—and see you at the next congress!

